

TAMBARAM

Chromepet » Pallavaram » Tambaram West » Rajakilpakkam » Mannivakkam » Guindy » Keelkattalai » Nanganallur » Guduvanchery » Hasthinapuram » Pammal » Tambaram East

Medavakkam » Srinivasa Nagar » Kathipara Junction » Kovilambakkam » Sadasivam Nagar » Potheri » Selaiyur » Sembakkam » St.Thomas Mount » Madipakkam » Urappakkam » Paranur



FEDERATION URGES COLLECTOR TO ACT

Waterbody protection, traffic congestion, encroachments and taxation among key concerns raised **P2**



PARK YOUR CAR OVER YOUR OPEN WELL

With the right design, an open well need not be a space taker; it can instead offer space for parking **P6**



Snapshots of the campaign.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

A campaign using the humble India Post postcard is not new, at least on the southern outskirts of Chennai where various residents' groups are fighting to save waterbodies besides other civic battles.

On Independence Day, after the flag-hoisting ceremony, Sri Sarvamangala Nagar Residents' Association in Chitlapakkam concluded its postcard campaign by keeping a cardboard box at the park. This is the RWA's third such postcard campaign, 2017, 2018-2019 being the previous years when they voiced their grievances writing on this yellow card and saw success.

On August 15, the general body meeting of the RWA was also taking place, so there was good attendance.

Residents had addressed letters to M. Veerappan, Collector, Chengalpattu district; Prashant M. Wadnere, Secretary, Water Resources Department; C. Joseph Vijay, Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu; N. Anand, Minister for Water Resources, and D. Sarath Kumar, MLA, Tambaram Assembly constituency. All the letters were dropped in the same box.

The spotlight of the campaign this time was on saving Sembakkam lake.

While some of them urged the IAS officials and the elected representatives to ensure rainwater flows into the sprawling Sembakkam lake, many others wanted

Plea on a postcard

For the third time, Sri Sarvamangala Nagar Residents' Association in Chitlapakkam has taken up this peaceful form of protest to express their angst over what they call official apathy towards the Sembakkam lake

Tambaram City Municipal Corporation to prevent sewage inflow into the lake. Other measures that ought to be taken were also written down, and these included placing boundary stones and strengthening the lake bunds in accordance with the Field Measurement Book.

M. Ravi, the Association secretary, says, "The Association has sent around 600 letters through post offices in Chitlapakkam, Chromepet, Selaiyur and Tambaram (West) regions."

Over the years the postcard campaign has also improved, ensuring maximum participation of residents.

"In the previous two campaigns, the letters were addressed to the Directorate of Municipal Administration and the Chief Secretary, urging them to make Tambaram Municipality into a Corporation and also include Chitlapakkam re-

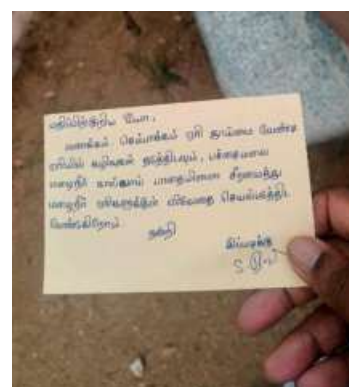
gion in the civic body," says Ravi.

They also campaigned for an underground drainage system, save Chitlapakkam and Sembakkam lakes, and implement Chembarambakkam Integrated Drinking Water Scheme.

Out of the seven issues, they have met with results in five. "Tambaram Municipality has been upgraded to Tambaram City Municipal Corporation, and the former Chitlapakkam Selection Grade Town Panchayat is now part of Tambaram Corporation. State Government has sanctioned the underground drainage project but the civic body is yet to float tenders. Chitlapakkam Lake has been restored and Chembarambakkam Integrated Drinking Water Scheme has been implemented" says Ravi.

Only the Sembakkam and other lakes have to be rejuvenated.

Earlier, they distributed and re-



where to drop off the cards, some came to the association joint treasurer's home.

Earlier, the association took the cards to the post office. This time, the residents posted close to 400 cards on their own," adds Ravi, happy to see more residents involved.

Similar campaigns

Chitlapakkam Muthulakshmi Nagar Residents Welfare Association seems to be a veteran when it comes to taking up postcard campaigns. L. Sundararaman, president of the Association says they first initiated this drawing the attention of the authorities in the 1990s to protect Chitlapakkam Lake from the State Government's housing project planned in the lake area. "If the lake is alive today then a good share of the credit should go to the Association, as the locality is one of the oldest in the region and it was the first to take up issues," says Sundararaman. In 2016, the Association conducted postcard campaigns to restore the Chitlapakkam lake and Sembakkam lake and to construct an underground drainage system. "Postcard campaigns are a peaceful form of protest aimed at rallying people together," said Sundararaman, adding that petitions to improve bus connectivity were also taken up in the past.

ceived the cards at the residents' doorsteps (around 300 homes are in the locality). This time we distributed the cards, but residents came forward to put them in the box.

"Even after August 15, a good number of residents called to ask

Federation urges Collector to act on pending civic issues

Waterbody protection, traffic congestion, encroachments and taxation among key concerns raised

T. ARVIND

Members of the Federation of Civic and Welfare Associations in Zones 2 and 3 of Tambaram Corporation, led by its secretary C. Murugaiyan, met Chengalpattu District Collector M. Veerappan recently and submitted a representation seeking action on eight long-pending public welfare issues.

The Federation raised issues relating to the protection of lakes and waterbodies in Tambaram and surrounding areas, traffic congestion, the proposed railway subway near Vaishnava College, electricity infrastructure, waste management and taxation.

The demands included:

Vaishnava College railway gate subway: The Federation urged the authorities to implement the 2014 project report for a subway capable of accommodating government bus services, citing correspondence from the Highways Department's Divisional Engineer.

Encroachment removal: It sought action against illegal structures on major roads, particularly Rajendra Prasad Road, as assured by the Corporation earlier.

Waterbody protection: The Federation sought concrete measures to protect lakes and natural drainage channels, referring to an assurance given by the Executive Engineer on July 26, 2024.



Chengalpattu Collector M. Veerappan peruses the representation submitted by C. Murugaiyan, secretary of the Federation of Civic and Welfare Associations in Zones 2 and 3 of Tambaram Corporation, in Chengalpattu recently.

PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Hasthinapuram sub-station: It sought expediting the establishment of the sanctioned electricity sub-station in Hasthinapuram.

Waste management: The Federation urged the district administration

to withdraw the directive requiring residents of multi-storey apartment complexes to manage their own municipal waste.

GST Road traffic: It sought the immediate removal of the median

barricade near Saravana Stores on GST Road to ease congestion.

Taxation: The Federation sought strict adherence to existing Government Orders and administrative circulars while levying prop-

erty and local taxes to avoid placing an undue burden on the public.

G.O. 114: It urged all government departments to comply with G.O. 114, dated August 2, 2008, which mandates written responses to petitions submitted by recognised public welfare associations.

Mr. Murugaiyan said the Collector had instructed his administrative team to place all eight demands on the agenda of an upcoming joint departmental coordination meeting involving the relevant government authorities.

"Though all the eight demands require attention, our immediate concern is the need to retrieve and restore lost waterbodies," Murugaiyan said. "Considering future generations, the authorities should act fast to restore lakes that are being damaged by sewage discharge, invasive vegetation and encroachments," he said.

He alleged that authorities were turning a blind eye to illegal encroachments despite multiple court orders directing that no sympathy be shown to encroachers.

Separately, the Federation urged the Tambaram Corporation Commissioner to convene a meeting of stakeholders, including residents, activists and officials, at least once every three months to discuss pending civic issues.

"Instead of relying solely on inputs from officials, the Government and the Corporation should obtain first-hand information and act on ground realities," Murugaiyan said. Meanwhile, members of the People's Awareness Forum, led by senior activists Santhanam and Meenakshisundaram, performed *aarthi* and offered floral tributes at Pallavaram lake on August 27, in a symbolic appeal to the Water Resources Department to take steps to stop sewage from entering the lake and an action plan to remove water hyacinth.

Transforming lives through movement

From a modest space in Lyolds Road to its current location in Meenambakkam, Mukti: M.S. Dadha Foundation has come a long way

The Meenambakkam-based Mukti: M.S. Dadha Foundation celebrated its 40th year of service with a belief it continues to drive – "Disability should never define a person's possibilities."

For four decades, the non-profit has been working towards



The core team of Mukti.

creating a more inclusive society by providing artificial limbs, calipers, physiotherapy and mobility support free of cost to persons with disabilities. Its journey has been driven by the goal of ensuring disability never becomes a barrier to dignity, independence and opportunity. Its annual booklet features what some of its beneficiaries have gone to achieve is just a proof of that, says a press release.

As part of its 40th year celebrations, Mukti has taken up a host of initiatives. A job fair for its beneficiaries was organised recently, creating opportunities for persons with disabilities to move towards financial independence and a more secure fu-

ture. This year, Mukti also conducted rehabilitation and support camps across seven locations, benefitting nearly 800 people, says the release. Mukti has been conducting monthly wheelchair distributions for 100 beneficiaries. To date, 500 wheelchairs have been distributed.

Mukti organised a wheelchair distribution event for 100 beneficiaries and an artificial limb distribution programme, on August 25 at its office on Station Road, Meenambakkam, the later was supported by Shree SS Jain Sanskar Manch Mahila Shakha.

The programme was held in the presence of Vimalchand Ji Dhariwal, president, Founder and Managing Trustee, KIND.

For more details, visit www.muktiindia.org.



Calling all adorable little Krishnas & Radhas!

Join us in celebrating Janmashtami by adorning your little ones as Krishna or Radha! Capture their delightful performances, whether it's dancing, singing, or reciting slokas, and share them with us for a chance to win exciting prizes. This contest is open to children aged 3 to 8 years.



To participate:

Scan the QR code or visit: newsth.live/THMK2026.
Upload a 1-2 minute video of your kid's performance
and a picture on our microsite.

**Registrations close
on September 7, 2026**

For queries, contact: **+91 81487 48183 / 90030 77030**

Terms and Conditions

Registrations close on September 7, 2026. The performance will be judged based on costumes, creativity & presentation. Submission of previous year's work will lead to immediate disqualification.

Associate Sponsor



Water Partner



Food Partner



Gift Partners





Atho is a gift Indians repatriated from Burma gave to Madras, their new home. And by owning and relishing this dish, Madras gave them a sense of connection with their past, people and culture as return gift

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

People marry into money. Abdul Rahman married into "Atho". And the latter situation translates to money saved by the plates. "I have never had to pay for a plate of Atho after marriage," Rahman chuckles.

Rahman is the son-in-law of Abdul Ajeez, whose eponymous Ajeez Atho Shop at Arrababu Street off Rajaji Salai in George Town has the effect of a speed governor on an environment geared to movement and bustle. The milling crowd on Rajaji Salai contrasts with the stationary, slurping crowd around Ajeez's shop. Customers, their work bags slung over their shoulders, tuck into plates of Atho as if it were their comfort food.

Atho shops in this part of George Town present these two scenarios. Local residents "own" Atho as one would a home-grown dish, treating it as a gift from Madras; a good number of them are likely unaware of the Burma backstory. And those Indians who left Burma (now Myanmar) for Madras find that connection with the Burma of the past sustained through Atho's popularity in this city. Through it, they also enjoy a sense of community among their own. Take these illustrations.

At Arrababu Street, Ajeez Atho Shop is at a vantage point enjoying

clear visibility from Rajaji Salai but patronage does not derive entirely from that factor. Rahman observes that with Ajeez, selling Atho has never merely been a business. With parents having lived in Burma, and leaving it behind for India, specifically Madras, as repatriates following the coup d'état in 1962, Ajeez views making and selling Atho as a bridge to his culture and people. This passion runs in the family. Rahman notes that his relatives operate similar Atho stalls in Trichy and Kutralam, further reinforcing food's known status as a mark of culture and community.

Legacy food should have secret recipes. Rahman insists there is no secret recipe; the true craft lies entirely in the balance of mixing and proportion. The shop caters to every craving with its main varieties: vegetarian, fried, and egg Atho, each customised to individual spice tolerances. Crucially, vegetarian and non-vegetarian preparation areas are kept strictly separate, ensuring no one's dietary preferences are compromised.

Ajeez operates from this spot for 20 years but has been in the Atho business for twice that number of years. After 40 years, he has found allies in his sons, Haider Ali and Yusuf. "On days my father-in-law is out of station or not well, his sons take care of the stall," observes Rahman.

And Rahman points out he does not assist in the running of the shop, just content being an avid Atho taster. And also volunteering to be a spokesperson, as he did for

Naturalised in Madras



Ajeez Atho Shop at Arrababu Street; and Shahul Hameed's shop at Second Line Beach Road in George Town.

this interview. Rahman points out the stall has appeared on several media platforms and attracted many VIPs who visit the stall during the less crowded hours.

Blurring of hierarchies

Shahul Hameed is the boss, and he is aged 30. Vincent Alphonse reports to Shahul at his Atho stall on Second Line Beach Road, and is more than twice his boss' age, having been born in 1962. The usual

hierarchical boss-worker relationship is missing. Deference to age does not entirely account for this behaviour. Shared histories and family connections explain it better. The forbears of both men are from Burma having come to Madras as repatriates following the 1962 coup. Repatriates Khadija Beevi and her husband started this shop 45 years ago and handed over its reins to their son Shahul. They have made sure their trusted lieute-

A dish's bio data

Here is Atho's biodata. Street food. Born in Burma. Naturalised in Madras. It is a hugely spicy form of noodles paired with shredded vegetables and the spiciness comes from a range of flavourings, which include chilli flakes, garlic, tamarind and fried onion. There is poetry to how it is made: the noodles along with its pairings is tossed by hand.

nant Vincent Alphonse who has worked with them for 30 years, is by their son's side assisting him. When his parents arrived in Madras from Burma in 1965, Alphonse was three years old, and his siblings were also children of tender years. Probably due to the effect of shared histories and family bonds and age, Shahul lets Vincent do the talking. One thing Vincent holds close to his heart is the customers telling him how conspicuous his absence is on the days he is not present in the shop. The cart draws bankers, lawyers, and college students, serving them vegetable, chicken, and fried Atho, alongside mohinga noodles traditionally accompanied by soup and banana stem. Vincent however notes mohinga has never matched Altho's popularity. Vincent says the secret of a good Atho moves far beyond its cooking process; it is in the mixing. Every component must come together correctly for the taste to emerge perfectly. He remarks fried atho is an entirely Indian twist to the Burmese dish. The cart employs around five people for smooth functioning. The sales dip during periods of religious abstinence from non-vegetarian food, but vegetable Atho sufficiently fills the gap and, Vincent says, has the highest demand. Vincent's composed voice could not hide his immense pride as he spoke about how the shop received a Vijay TV award for Best Navu (Meal) in 2012, an honour he credits to their taste. He adds that the shop holds an FSSAI certification, with employees having participated in food safety meetings.

Further down Second Line Beach Road, another Atho stall, called Burma Atho Shop, carries the same sense of a legacy being passed on. Rahamathulla took over the business from his uncle who had learnt the art of making Atho in Burma. And he makes it the way his uncle taught him. However, along the way, he has also tweaked Atho to suit local taste buds. His menu has grown to nearly 10 choices, spanning vegetable and fried Atho, including chicken and egg versions, with customers able to adjust the spice and flavours to their liking. And thereby he enables Burma, Madras and Chennai coexist, defying the limitations of time and geography.

As part of Madras Week, Resilience Series tracks traders and markets that have adapted to changing times and thrived in the city that was once called Madras



From a recent competition and (below) the team that won the second place at the national tournament.

A triumph both on and off the goalball court

Greater awareness about goalball needs to be created so that the visually challenged take it up

LIFFY THOMAS

Viewed at a surface level, the Tamil Nadu team's great showing in the Indian Blind Sports Association's "Second Youth National Goalball Championship 2026", where it took the second place, is just another victory in a sporting arena. At a deeper level, this victory signals other victories.

For one, it is a victory for the Goalball Association of Tamil Nadu, a registered body just a year old, for its successful efforts to stitch together a team comprising visually impaired students from small towns and difficult economic backgrounds. Many of them look at sports as a ticket to a stable government job.

R. Barath, a final year student of Presidency College, grew up in a joint family in Erode. His single father and uncle are visually challenged. Just three months ago, he learnt about the sport from a friend and got selected to the state team. "There are many blind students like me at Presidency College, Queen Mary's College and Nandanam Arts College. Conducting awareness sessions about this sport will encourage many more to join it and benefit they way I have," he says

A short put and javelin thrower, Ahilendiran D from Madurai got to



The history of it

Invented in 1946 as a rehabilitation sport for visually impaired World War II veterans, the sport evolved into a competitive discipline and gained international recognition. In 1976, Goalball was officially introduced as a Paralympic sport at the Toronto Paralympic Games. Played by two teams of three players each in an indoor court that roughly measures the size of a volleyball court (18mx9m), goalball relies on auditory skills, teamwork and tactical awareness. A bell inside the ball allows players to track movement through sound. All players wear opaque eye masks to allow players with varying degree of blindness to compete on an equal footing. Players roll or throw the ball hard along the floor to get it past the opposing team's defence and into a 9-metre-wide goal. Today, goalball is played in more than 100 countries and is said to be one of the most inspiring team sports in the Paralympic movement. For details, visit <https://tngoalball.in/> or call 93449 87893

know about goalball from his coach. An orphan, Ahilendiran supports his family taking up part-time jobs. After this victory, he hopes they get to compete in recognised competitions and more people and organisations come forward to sponsor them as well. Rajasthan Youth Association Foundation sponsored them for the just-concluded event.

A judo coach for the blind, V. Maheswaran from Salem was roped in to coach the boys team noticing the interest he showed in the para sport. He picked up the sport watching videos online and with the help of his son. "We all are learning and getting better with every competition. When we had the selection camp in Chennai, we sought help from members of Telangana team," says Maheswaran. Proud that three of his judo students have landed government jobs, he says, sports is not a level-playing field especially for those with disabilities and more organisations should come to empower students to take up sports.

For the national tournament, participants have to wear an eye patch but each costs more than ₹ 3,000, so we just tied a black cloth and played, he says.

Finding new talent

Visually challenged G.R. Bharathi Raja, who started the Tamil Nadu Blind Football Association in 2019, is also coaching students in goalball. He says goalball is specially designed for those with vision problems and teaches players life skills, builds physical strength and helps with coordination.

The Association is looking at conducting more awareness workshops in schools and colleges about goalball. Their first workshop had 45 students participating in it. "We are happy to visit institutions with visually challenged students to conduct more sessions and groom a new generation of players," says Bharathi Raja, who works with Indian Bank.

Besides accessible facilities to play and practise, the sport needs support on many other fronts.

Vidyashankar B, chairperson, Goalball Association of Tamil Nadu, wants the State Government to reward players who win national and international tournaments with cash awards.

Bringing players together at one space is a challenge. "If every district allots a space in a stadium for goalball then it saves the travel time, cost incurred for food and accommodation for many of these players who come from humble backgrounds," says Vidyashankar, who works with an IT company and is grateful to the support from Lit the Light Trust where he was a volunteer.

Finally, for players with visual disabilities it is not just about winning medals but to show to the world they can compete in a para sport.



An open well in Besant Nagar.

FILE PHOTO: KARUNAKARAN M

With the right design, an open well need not be a space taker; it can instead offer space for parking or anything else in addition to providing water-related benefits, as these communities in Chennai discovered with the help of The Rain Centre

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

For many apartment residents in Chennai, an open well may sound like something from another time – a structure with a parapet wall, a pulley and a bucket. With space at a premium, keeping one may seem impractical. But an open well does not necessarily mean giving up a parking spot or valuable open space. With the right design, it can be built below ground, allowing vehicles to pass over it while the well continues to collect rainwater and recharge groundwater.

This is what N. Ramshankar, an executive member of The Rain Centre, has done at the Rain Centre in Adyar. An old open well that once had only about two feet of water now holds around 16 feet after rooftop rainwater was direct-

Park your car over your open well

ed into it with minimal filtration.

Sekhar Raghavan, director, The Rain Centre, weighs in about this open well on the premises of the Rain Centre: “Unless I open the lid, you will not even know that there is an open well below.” Such wells can even be incorporated into driveways or parking areas, Sekhar says, provided they are kept away from structural columns. “You can have your open well within your stilt car parking,” says Sekhar. The minimum space required for the well, according to him, is about 3.25 feet in diameter.

“We were afraid in the initial days. We were wondering whether an open well can be closed and whether it will accumulate gas and all that. An engineer told us, ‘Don’t make that mistake, nothing will happen.’ He even set up a vent for us,” says Ramshankar. The parapet wall was subsequently removed and a slab was placed at floor level. “We demolished the parapet wall of the well and then we put a slab on it, at the floor level. Now we have vehicles going on top of it,” he says.

The benefit has not been limited to saving space. The quality of

the water has also improved. “The TDS has also been diluted from almost 850 to now 400,” he says.

For Ramshankar, the value of an open well lies in what it can provide while also being replenished. Open wells generally tap the shallow aquifer, around 25 to 30 feet below the ground and, at most, about 40 feet. Unlike the deeper hard-rock aquifer tapped by borewells, this shallow groundwater can be replenished more easily through rainwater harvesting. Rooftop rainwater can be directed into an existing well, replenishing the water and helping dilute salts and TDS.

Sekhar Raghavan says open wells generally tap the shallow groundwater layer, which can be replenished through rainwater harvesting.

“During monsoon, your open well will have a lot of water, and a couple of months thereafter. So,

We made these collection pits at every gate and diverted the water to the percolation pits.

start tapping it. Then during summer months, go to your borewell,” he says. For an apartment, this can also translate into a reduction in dependence on tanker water.

Keeping the tankers away

At Hiranya Apartments in Raja Annamalaipuram, resident Raghunandan Ranganathan says the open well was never shut, even though three borewells had been installed and two were later closed. “This open well is what is giving us a lot of water,” he says.

The apartment already had rainwater-harvesting infrastructure, including percolation wells. But during heavy rain, water would collect in the compound and flow out through the gates onto the road. The residents then sought Sekhar Raghavan's help.

“We made these collection pits at every gate and diverted the water to the percolation pits, which in turn were feeding the well,” says Raghunandan. Over time, the system changed the quality and availability of water in the apartment.

“Builders often do not make use of the open wells available on

a property. Instead, they tend to shut them down and install borewells. I am not able to understand the logic behind this.”

Making use of the monsoon

At Bayview Apartments in Besant Nagar, the open well has been in use since the apartment was built around 1989-90. “We are using an open well. Generally, during the rain, mainly after the Northeast Monsoon, it fills up,” says resident K. Sangameshwar.

The apartment also has two borewells and a Metro Water connection. During the rainy season, residents use more of the open well and borewell. Rainwater from the terrace is directed towards the ground, with parts of the system leading close to the open well. The complex also has rainwater-harvesting pits in its open areas. “So all these go into the well, and from the well, I think it slowly percolates into the groundwater,” says Sangameshwar.

Unlike the well at The Rain Centre, the Bayview well remains above ground, with a cover and mesh over it. It shows that there is no single way for an apartment to retain an open well. It can remain visible in an open space, or it can be covered and integrated into a driveway or parking area.

For apartment residents, then, the question may not be whether there is enough space for an open well. It could be whether the space already available can be put to better use – above the ground for parking, and below it for water

MMC batch of 1976 to meet on September 11

VARADARAJAN KALIDASAN

Our batch of Madras Medical College, the Batch of 1976 which was selected to undertake the MBBS course during the Emergency Period of 1976, is now coming together again to celebrate its Golden Jubilee. Many of us have not met each other for four decades or more.

Over the years we have worked in different parts of the world, from far-flung Australia, New Zealand, Southeast Asia, South Africa, the United Kingdom and the United States of America. Many of us have contributed significantly not just to the healthcare of the people around the world but towards research, education and administration. Some have made huge contributions within India too, including serving in the Armed Forces. Wherever we have been, we have flown the flag high for our country and our institution.

Examples of such people include Prof. Vani Rao at the Johns Hopkins University, USA; Prof. Murali M. Chintagumpala at the Texax



A group photo of the Batch and snapshots of other get-togethers.

Children's Hospital, Houston; Prof. C. Rajkumar at the Brighton and Sussex Medical School; Prof. V. Kalidasan who has been previously director of medical education in Brighton and held honorary appointments including in China and at the Royal College of Surgeons in Edinburgh. In India Dr. Amar Agar

wal and his wife Dr. Athiya (also from our Batch) have created the chain of the famous Agarwal Eye hospitals; other famous practitioners include Dr. Lakshmanan of the AVM hospitals in Thoothukudi, Dr. Vimallesh Lysander from Lysander hospital in Virudhunagar and Dr. S. Sridhar in MIOT hospitals. These

are but a few examples of those who have cared for and contributed to our society and we cannot forget Colonel Dr. Anbunathan who was a paratrooper and served in the Indian Army with great distinction.

In addition, through the contact we have with the Rotary Club

(in which Dr. Mahender, from our batch and his wife Dr. Anuradha are very active) we are participating in a campaign called the Pink Auto Project. Our batch has collected sufficient funds to fund five autorickshaws which will be given to five suitable women chosen by the Rotarians. This will help them to sustain their families independently. We are also donating two defibrillators (AEDs) to be placed in suitable public locations where they could be life-saving. It is to be noted that out of a possible 120 classmates over 110 are making the trip to the meet. We have unfortunately lost 21 classmates over the years. We will remember them on this occasion with great fondness.

We are meeting at the old campus of the Madras Medical College near the famous Red Fort Anatomy building on September 11, 9 a.m. We will be having a group photo and participate in a campus walkaround.

(Dr. Varadarajan Kalidasan, who practises in England, is an alumnus of Madras Medical College from the 1976 batch)

Televisions with RGB technology



Sony launched its latest 'Bravia True RGB Televisions' at an event held at Girias Showroom in Mahalingapuram.

Sony is committed to delivering superior picture quality and an immersive viewing experience through its innovative True RGB technology, said a release.

To celebrate the festive season, the multinational conglomerate

has announced a special promotional offer on its newly launched Bravia True RGB televisions.

Customers can avail attractive cashback offers, a 1-EMI-free scheme, and a complimentary three-year warranty. The new Bravia True RGB Televisions are now available at Girias showrooms, the release added.

Final day of Pothys 'Kolusu Kondattam'

Pothys Swarna Mahal, a leading jewellery retailer, has brought tradition and contemporary style with its 'Kolusu Kondattam' mela, held across its showrooms in the State.

Featuring an impressive collection of over 5,000 designs, the mela offers customers an extensive choice of plain, antique, and designer silver anklets.

Customers can purchase plain silver anklets with no making charges and GST. Customers will pay only for the silver weight and the prevailing silver rate. In addition, antique and fancy designer anklets are available at a 10 percent discount off the maximum retail price, said a release.

The showrooms are on GST Road, Chromepet; Rukmani Nagar, Poona-mallee; C.T.H. Road, Padi; and in Coimbatore, Salem, Tirunelveli, and Trichy.

Special camp by MTC on Sept 2

The Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC) has invited applications from Industrial Training Institute (ITI) students (Mechanic Motor Vehicle, Mechanic Diesel, Electrician, Auto Electrician, Fitter, Turner, Painter, Welder) for a one-year professional acquaintance in ITI, with a stipend of ₹ 14,000 per month. On September 2, MTC will conduct a special camp from 10 a.m. at the Industrial Training Institute, Chromepet, where students can apply for the one-year training program, said a release from the MTC.

Special trains between Tambaram and Velankanni

The following special trains will be operated to clear the extra rush of passengers during the Annai Velankanni Festival.

Train No. 06037 Tambaram - Velankanni weekly express special will leave Tambaram at 23.50

p.m., on 31st August, and 07th September (Monday), and reach Velankanni at 07.45 a.m. the next day.

In the return direction, Train No. 06038 Velankanni - Tambaram weekly express special will leave Velankanni at 00.45 a.m. on

02nd, and 09th September (Wednesday), and reach Tambaram at 07.30 a.m. the next day.

The trains will stop at Chengalpattu, Villupuram, Cuddalore Port, Chidambaram, Mayiladuthurai, Thirunallaru, Karaikal, Nagore, and Nagapattinam.

\$ MARUTI SUZUKI

ARENA

For Service Booking Call

AUTO TECH

Ph : 97100 11888
044 - 223 88888

No.6, 1st Street,
Kamatchi Colony,
Sanatorium,
Chennai 600 047.

பலப்பை, வண்டலூர்,
கடுவாஞ்சேரி பகுதியில்
வீடுகட்ட அணுகவும்

K R CONSTRUCTIONS
BUILDING CONTRACTOR
& ENGINEER

BUDGET FRIENDLY BUILDERS

PLANS
CONSTRUCTION
LABOUR CONTRACT

8072 499969

To advertise in

DOWNTOWN

Contact:

UDHAYAKUMAR
81246 14787

KALAIVANI
OLD AGE HOME
@
EAST TAMBARAM

Contact:

98843 67968
89392 76861

Coding their way to confidence

From village classrooms to a State-level competition at IIT-M Research Park, young minds are making their mark with digital skills



KANNAL ACHUTHAN

When Iniyasri, a school student from Uthukottai in Thiruvallur district, learnt that she would be making a visit to IIT-Madras this month, she simply could not contain her joy. She was one of the students to be selected to make a presentation that would reflect the digital and computer literacy skills that she had acquired with the help of the Chennai chapter of voluntary organisation Asha for Education.

“Last time, I was not selected to come to IIT, but this time I made it,” says Iniyasri, who is now learning Scratch at a rural training centre (RTC) run by Asha. She showed off her newly acquired skills with a project on the universe at a competition where students from 13 RTCs across Tamil Nadu

participated.

Volunteers at Asha Chennai have worked steadily to bring the RTC programme to this point. The programme that started with just two RTCs in 2022 has now grown into a thriving initiative reaching nearly 1,200 students. The RTCs provide free six-month courses for students from Classes 6 to 12. While every centre begins with digital literacy, students can progress to programming, web development, robotics and AI as their skills develop.

The excitement of the students, most of whom were from government schools in villages, could hardly be contained within the walls of Raman Hall in the IIT-M Research Park during the competition. Rather than allow the high-pressure environment to dampen their spirits, the students confidently showed their projects to the experts who had come to judge the event. The 18 judges included pro-

fessionals from Amazon, Ford, Accenture, Cisco, Wipro and several start-up companies. Professors from Rajalakshmi Engineering College and BITS Pilani were also among the judges.

This round in the State capital saw students from 13 centres submit 482 projects across digital literacy, Scratch programming, web development, physical computing, robotics, media editing, JavaScript animations and AI. Of these, 64 projects were selected for presentation at IIT-M. The projects reflected both the students’ technical learning and their everyday interests. Scratch projects included games, science topics and environmental themes. Students working on websites tackled subjects ranging from agriculture to food delivery management. Robotics students developed ideas such as cleaning robots, pollution detectors and smart agriculture systems.



Glimpses of the event held at IIT-Madras. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Volunteer Rajaraman Krishnan, who has been with Asha Chennai for over two decades, said that students have been so engaged with the programme that many have continued attending the RTCs over the years. One of them is doing an internship with Asha Chennai now, he added.

Jayavel, one of the judges, said,

“The students were impressive, not just because of what they had built, but also because they had learned and understood their projects well and were able to explain their ideas clearly. It is great to see children getting the opportunity to learn technology, experiment with it, and build things on their own.”

Madras Week celebrated on a train ride

When Madras Day arrived, Chennai welcomed it on the move with a musical Metro ride; the celebration was punctuated with a pause to show commuters how to use the Metro with civic sense

At the stroke of midnight, as August 22 turned into Madras Day, 150 Chennaiites boarded a Metro train at Chennai Central for a freshly aligned troika: music, community and Metro awareness. The three-fold experience was jointly organised by Super Chennai and Chennai Metro Rail Limited (CMRL) to celebrate the city through moving snapshots of it, as well as appreciate its lifeline, the Metro that gives it movement.

At the Chennai Central Metro sta-

tion, before the participants embarked on the Metro ride, a cake was cut by the CMRL mascot. On the ride, Chennai-based folk music ensemble Office Gaana took their place across two compartments. Special arrangements ensured that passengers seated across both compartments could experience the concert. Office Gaana launched into one song after another in their distinctive folk style, turning the Metro into a moving sing-along, says a press release. Passengers sang along,



clapped, grooved and, at several points, even moved to the floor of the compartments to get closer to the music. For nearly an hour, the train became a celebration on wheels, travelling from Chennai Central to Arumbakkam and back.

The midnight ride doubled as a Metro awareness initiative, with announcements and messages woven into the musical journey. Participants were reminded about simple

but important aspects of using the Metro responsibly – allowing passengers to alight before boarding, keeping the coaches clean, following safety guidelines, respecting fellow commuters and making the best use of the Metro system. J Roddick, one of the participants, travelled from Padur in OMR.

“The moment they opened registrations, I thought this was going to be one insane experience that I

should not miss,” he said. “Madras Day has grown tremendously over the years, with people from different walks of life coming together to celebrate the city. We wanted to create an experience that reflected the Chennai of today – young, energetic, rooted in its culture, but constantly looking for new experiences,” said Ranjeeth Rathod, MD, Super Chennai.

Gold Bell
Foundation

2BHK
1000 SQFT
INDEPENDENT HOUSE

3BHK
1300 SQFT
INDEPENDENT HOUSE

9 @ SELAIYUR, KASPABURAM

93 LAKHS ONLY

1.05 CRORE ONLY

CALL NOW 9841983310